Sentinels of the Dawn

Newsletter of the Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration

Monastère de Notre Dame des Anges Troyes

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In the Light of God; Saint Clare of Assisi

At the close of the 12th century, life in Assisi, a small city tucked away in Monte Subasio, was soon to change. Legend has it that an expectant mother was quite apprehensive as she awaited the birth of her child. She would frequently visit a nearby church and one day heard the following response to her prayer for the safe delivery of this child: "O lady, do not be afraid, for you will joyfully bring forth a clear light which will illumine the world." (*The Legend and Writings of Saint Clare*) Within a short time the child was born and given the name of Chiara or Clare.



Palm Sunday, 1212: The time arrives for this "light" to shine forth. Unknown to her family, Clare steals away in the night, leaving behind everything— loved ones, a life of nobilty and wealth—in exchange for one of complete poverty. Her one desire is to embrace the new "gospel way of living" initiated by Francis, the Poverello of Asssi. On this particular evening, Francis meets her at the Portiuncula, the chapel dedicated to Our Lady of the Angels. There Clare is clothed in a coarse habit, and her head veiled, after her long and beautiful blond tresses are shorn, a clear sign to all that she is no longer of the world. Soon after, Clare's sister, Agnes, joins her along with several others who are eager to do likewise. Thus, the Order of the Poor Ladies is born.

The Rule and writings which she left behind reflect not only her desire to live in total poverty and humility, but also her dedication to imitate Saint Francis' vision of an evangelical way of life. It is, therefore, not difficult to understand why she called herself the "little plant of the most blessed Francis". Hidden away in the shadows of the cloister for over 40 years, Clare's faith is proclaimed in the secret fecundity of the root which in obscurity and oblivion is made to flourish and bear fruit for the entire Franciscan Order.

Many representations portray Our Holy Mother Clare holding a monstrance containing the Eucharist. Through her devotion and firm confidence in God, the Saracens, who threatened to invade the monastery of San Damiano, are put to flight. This image mirrors Clare's entire life, for it reflects her strong, courageous faith, which struggled against and overcame the lures of the world. In one of her letters, Our Holy Mother Clare exhorts her daughters to look into the mirror, which signifies none other than Christ Himself, the "mirror without spot." (*4th Letter of St. Clare to Blessed Agnes of Prague*) Daily, she encouraged her Sisters to "study therein your countenance, that within and without you may adorn yourself with all manner of virtues, and clothe yourself with the flowers and garments that become the daughter and chaste spouse of the most high King. In that mirror are reflected poverty, holy humility and ineffable charity, as with the grace of God, you may perceive." (*from the same letter as stated above*) We, as Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration, wish to follow her example by constantly gazing upon this "mirror of Eternity"and at the same time invite others to come and adore Him, truly present in the Holy Eucharist. It is before the Most Blessed Sacrament that we can experience the power of His Mercy and Love, so as to be renewed daily by His grace and to bear fruit through our very lives, which helps to build up the Kingdom of God.

Saint Clare's mission shines forth ever more brightly in this day and age, through her spiritual daughters. Many young women continue to walk in the footsteps of the poor Crucified Christ with the same zeal which burned so strongly in the heart of our Holy Mother Clare. With "swift pace, light step and unswerving feet" (*2nd letter of St. Clare to Blessed Agnes of Prague*) each one advances along the path to which she has been called in pursuit of the one thing necessary—union with the Beloved Bridegroom. Each one's vocation is unique and unrepeatable, and we are reminded of this each time a new member joins the Community. We are particularly



Welcoming our newest arrival!

During a private ceremony, Rev. Mother receives our postulant into the community and presents her with the Postulant medal.





A Community photo before the image of Our Holy Mother Clare, who intercedes for us, as we follow in her footsteps.

grateful for our newest member who entered the monastery on the16th of July, which by no mere coincidence is the birthday of Our Holy Mother Clare We confide to your prayers our postulant, Shirley Lubreto, that during this first year of discernment and formation, she may grow in her knowledge and love of God, and come to better understand the life of a perpetual adorer of the Most Blessed Sacrament. We pray, too, that other young women will respond to this call of following in the ways of Our Holy Mother Clare through a life of poverty and humility, an evangelical life in union with the poor, Crucified Christ.

IN THANKSGIVING FOR OUR PRIESTS

The great Solemnity of Sts. Peter and Paul on June 29th, which opened the year of St. Paul proclaimed by our Holy Father Benedict XVI, also marked a number of events for which there was cause for rejoicing and offering thanks to God. The first was the patronal feast of the Cathedral of Troyes, which will be celebrating its 800th anniversary this coming fall. It is amazing to think of the all the detailed work involved in the construction and maintenance of this great spiritual edifice and just how many faithful have stepped foot into this "house of God" to worship and adore over the centuries. Our diocese had the great joy of witnessing on this grace-filled day the priestly ordination of two men— Narcisse Elemba and Mike Rosario— who are signs of hope for the Church, which is ever ancient, ever new. It also marked the anniversary ordination of several priests in the diocese, one of them being our chaplain, Father Bernard Savourat. Father Savourat was ordained in 1952 with five other priests in this same Cathedral of Sts. Peter and Paul. On the 8th of May, he along with three other priests, Fathers Michel Gattouillat, André Calon, and André-Pierre Vandewalle gathered together in our chapel to concelebrate a Mass in honor of their ordination anniversary. We were delighted to have them in our presence, to join them in this memorable event, and to offer them up in prayer in thanksgiving to God for their vocation, for their service to the Church and to the diocese of Troyes.



As mentioned in our first newsletter, our Bishop Marc Stenger gave us the wonderful Christmas gift of announcing that Father Savourat was to be our chaplain. Since the first part of January, when his new assignment officially began, he has been a continual blessing for our community through his celebration of our daily conventual Mass with his well-prepared homilies, along with the brief accounts of the lives of the saints of Troyes, at the opening of Mass on their feast days. His devotion, dedication, and availability are a great strength to each one of us.



Following the Church's ancient tradition of blessing fields before the planting season, we asked Father Savourat to bless ours during the Rogation Days. Unfortunately, on the afternoon of the blessing, there was a torrential downpour. This did not seem to dampen the spirits of Father nor our Sisters as we processed around the courtyard with candles and incense while chanting the Litany of the Saints. At the end of the Litany, Father blessed the land and the work of our hands.

On another occasion, Father Savourat and his friend, Father Roland Lefevre of the Foreign Missions of Paris offered Mass in our chapel. They returned to the monastery that same afternoon to visit our community.



Father Lefevre spent over 40 years in India, including the home states of four of our Sisters— Tamil Nadu and Kerala. What a delight to meet Father and learn of his many wonderful experiences through his missionary work in India. He was indeed an inspiration to our community and a source of encouragement to embrace and fulfill our own "mission" as well. Let us thank God for all priests and missionaries throughout the world. May the Queen of Clergy bless them in all their endeavors so that they may draw all people to her Son, Jesus, Who is the Way, the Truth and the Life.

FATHER ROLAND LEFEVRE RECOUNTS THE JOYS AND STRUGGLES OF MISSIONARY LIFE TO THE SISTERS.



The task of making chocolate covered bananas requires lots of sampling!



Franciscan joy is contagious... Our Sisters are all smiles due to the visit of two Poor Clares from Chamaliè-res, who stop-ped to see us on their way to a conference.

Back by popular demand- Our dog "Ma Belle" taking it easy, due to the summer heat!



Sowing and Reaping- a hundred-fold!



Decked out in work habits and veils, aprons and boots, the Sisters tackle the weeds.

First the sowing of seeds and then the reaping of the harvest, thanks to God's providence and the hard work of the Sisters.

"This is what the Kingdom of God is like. A man throws seed on the land. Night and day, while he sleeps, when he is awake, the seed is sprouting and growing; how he does not know. Of its own accord, the land produces first the shoot, then the ear, then the full grain in the ear. And when the crop is ready, he loses no time: he starts to reap because the harvest has come." (Mark 4, 26-29)

One of the big projects around the monastery this time of year has been the preparation and planting of our vegetable garden. A great work, indeed, for such a small number of Sisters, but one which has proved to be "life-giving" in more ways than we ever imagined!

In late spring, seeds were planted and watered with care— everything from onions, potatoes, and tomatoes to green beans, squash and melons! With each passing day our anticipation increased, as we waited patiently for new life to sprout. Brother Sun and Sister Rain helped the growth process by providing the necessary nourishment. And then one day, our first signs of produce appeared! In the meantime, one of the greatest challenges proved to be the weeds, which seemed to be growing faster than the vegetables themselves. Then the slugs appeared, who began feasting on our heads of lettuce, threatening to devour everything in such a short time. The birds too seemed to love our cherries. Do not God's little creatures need to eat as well?

Our vegetable garden has provided us not only with an abundant harvest of the fruits of the land through the work of our hands, but has also proved to be a wonderful learning experience. For some, it was a lesson of patience and perseverance: waiting on God' perfect timing, and not our own. The work was, at certain points, strenuous and demanding lots of time and attention, but at the same time rewarding and rich in blessings as we witnessed first-hand the fruits of our labor. For others, it was the realization of how much can be accomplished with the work of many hands. It was not the role of one single Sister, but each Sister's efforts, which were beneficial to the success of our work as a whole. Working and cooperating together reinforced for us the importance of community life. And finally, whether one was weeding, watering, or gathering the harvest, our hearts were filled with wonder and gratefulness for the works of God's creation, who manifests His providence and goodness to us. We cannot fail to thank all those who have helped us in ways, great and small. We are very grateful to a man, who wishes to re-main anonymous, and who has volunteered countless hours of his time tilling and fertilizing the soil and sharing his know-how, gained from experience in how to plant and care for our little corner of God's creation. A big thank you to those who provided us through their thoughtfulness and generosity with the necessary garden tools for our daily work, as well as those who came to our rescue with their advice and instructions of how to properly care for our garden. For each one of you, our prayerful thanks are raised to the Creator of all good things, which come to us from above. May He bless you a hundred-fold!

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Check out our newly launched website: www. clarissesdetroyes.org

Glimpses of the "before and after" in our vegetable garden







Connecting garden hoses– it's a dirty job, but our "Jacqueline of all trades "was up for the challenge!

Sister wins the "grand prize" for the largest veggie found in the pumpkin patch!



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